

Notes: Durante and Zhuravskaya (JPE, 2018)

Attack When the World Is Not Watching? US News and the Israeli-Palestinian Conflict

Contents

1	Big picture	2
2	Incremental contribution of this paper	2
3	Data and measurement	3
3.1	Conflict data	3
3.2	US news coverage of the conflict	3
3.3	News pressure	3
3.4	Predictable newsworthy events	4
3.5	Attack-type measures	4
4	Models and empirical specifications	4
4.1	Coverage equation	4
4.2	Attack timing equation	4
4.3	Severity and victim regressions	5
4.4	Predictable-event test	5
4.5	Attack-type multinomial models	5
5	Identification and empirical design	5
5.1	Core identifying idea	5
5.2	Main threats and responses	6
5.3	Why Israeli-Palestinian asymmetry is informative	6
5.4	What the design cannot fully prove	6
6	Section-by-section study guide	6
7	Tables and figures	8
7.1	Figure 1: Israeli and Palestinian Fatalities by Month + Table 1: News Pressure and the Length of Conflict-Related News	8
7.2	Table 2: Coverage of Conflict, News Pressure, and Google Searches + Figure 2: Coverage of Conflict in US News	9
7.3	Figure 3: Israeli and Palestinian Attacks and US News Pressure + Table 3: Israeli Attacks and News Pressure, Part 1	10
7.4	Table 3: Israeli Attacks and News Pressure, Part 2 + Table 4: Palestinian Attacks and News Pressure	11
7.5	Figure 4: Israeli and Palestinian Attacks and Other Predictable Newsworthy Events + Table 5: Israeli Attacks and News Pressure under Different Conditions, Part 1	12

7.6	Table 5: Israeli Attacks and News Pressure under Different Conditions, Part 2 + Table 6: The Urgency of Attacks and the Likelihood of Civilian Casualties, Part 1	13
7.7	Table 6: The Urgency of Attacks and the Likelihood of Civilian Casualties, Part 2 + Figure 5: Types of Attacks and News Pressure	14
7.8	Table 7: Google Search Volume, Conflict-Related News, and Timing of Attacks	15
8	Detailed result map	17
9	Short summary	17
10	Conclusion	17
10.1	Core conclusion	17
10.2	Economic intuition	17
10.3	Why the evidence is persuasive	18
10.4	Incremental lesson for political economy	18
10.5	Policy implications	18
10.6	Limitations	18
10.7	Final takeaway	18

1 Big picture

- **Core question.** Do governments and armed actors strategically time violence to reduce international media scrutiny?
- **Empirical setting.** The paper studies the Israeli-Palestinian conflict from 2000 to 2011 and links daily attack data to US television news coverage and competing US news pressure.
- **Mechanism.** US news programs have limited time. When other big stories occupy airtime, conflict-related stories are crowded out. If attackers dislike international scrutiny, they may time attacks for moments when competing news is expected to dominate.
- **Key variable.** *News pressure* measures how much nonconflict news competes for airtime on the major US evening news programs. The paper constructs both corrected and uncorrected measures.
- **First key finding.** Higher news pressure substantially reduces the probability and length of conflict coverage in US news, conditional on the severity of attacks.
- **Second key finding.** Israeli attacks against Palestinians are more likely immediately before high-news-pressure days. Palestinian attacks do not respond similarly.
- **Strategic interpretation.** The asymmetry is consistent with the idea that Israel, as the actor more exposed to US public opinion and diplomatic pressure, has stronger incentives and capacity to time attacks to avoid US attention.
- **Predictability evidence.** Israeli attacks are also more frequent just before predictable US political and sports events that absorb media attention. This supports the timing interpretation rather than a purely mechanical correlation.
- **Attack-type evidence.** The response to news pressure is strongest for attacks that are especially likely to generate reputational costs: attacks that are non-targeted, fatal, in high-density areas, or involve heavy weapons.
- **Demand-side validation.** Conflict coverage is associated with Google searches for the conflict, so media coverage plausibly captures public attention rather than only journalistic decisions.
- **Economic and political takeaway.** The paper shows that media attention is an input into strategic behavior. Political actors do not merely react to media; they anticipate the media agenda and adjust the timing of real actions.

2 Incremental contribution of this paper

- **From media effects to strategic avoidance of media.** Earlier work often asks whether media coverage affects voters, consumers, or policymakers. This paper asks whether policymakers and military actors strategically respond to the expected absence of media coverage.
- **Agenda congestion as quasi-random variation.** The paper introduces a daily “news pressure” design: when unrelated US stories crowd the news agenda, the same conflict event receives less coverage. This creates a way to study the cost of media attention without manipulating news directly.
- **A conflict-timing application.** The paper brings media-economics tools into international conflict. It shows that the timing of violence can be shaped by the global media calendar.
- **Actor asymmetry.** By comparing Israeli and Palestinian attacks, the paper distinguishes the actor with stronger reputational/diplomatic exposure to US media from the actor with weaker incentives and capacity to time attacks around US coverage.
- **Multiple validation layers.** The paper combines news coverage regressions, Google-search demand evidence, event-study timing around news pressure, predictable-event tests, and attack-type heterogeneity.

- **Contribution to political economy.** The paper provides evidence that transparency and accountability are time-varying. Accountability is weaker when audiences are distracted, and strategic actors can exploit this.
- **Contribution to empirical design.** The study demonstrates how external media congestion can serve as a source of variation for studying hidden or reputational costs of public actions.
- **Contribution to conflict studies.** The paper offers a micro-timing mechanism: not just whether violence occurs, but *when* it occurs, can depend on international attention.

3 Data and measurement

3.1 Conflict data

- The analysis uses daily data on Israeli and Palestinian attacks during 2000–2011.
- Outcomes include the occurrence of an attack, the number of victims, and attack characteristics such as targeted versus non-targeted, fatal versus nonfatal, high-density versus low-density area, and heavy versus light weapons.
- Israeli attacks against Palestinians and Palestinian attacks against Israelis are studied separately.
- The paper excludes periods of extremely intense combat, such as the Gaza War, in some baseline specifications because those episodes dominate both conflict intensity and news coverage.

Interpretation: The daily frequency is central. The question is not whether the conflict is more intense in some months or years; it is whether attacks shift by a day or two when the US media agenda is crowded.

3.2 US news coverage of the conflict

- Conflict coverage is measured from major US television news programs.
- The paper constructs whether conflict is covered and how many minutes are devoted to conflict-related stories.
- The coverage measure captures the visibility of the conflict to US audiences.
- The paper also uses Google search volume for Israeli-Palestinian conflict terms as a demand-side measure of public attention.

Interpretation: Coverage is the channel through which reputational and diplomatic costs arise. If attacks are hidden by other news, the international audience is less likely to notice or search for information.

3.3 News pressure

- News pressure measures the amount of competing nonconflict news on US television.
- The corrected measure adjusts for the mechanical fact that conflict stories themselves use time and therefore reduce available airtime for other stories.
- The uncorrected measure is more directly related to total airtime but is more mechanically affected by conflict coverage.
- Table 1 shows that conflict news mechanically reduces uncorrected news pressure but does not meaningfully change corrected news pressure.

Interpretation: Corrected news pressure is the preferred measure because it is intended to capture exogenous congestion in the US news agenda rather than the crowd-out created by conflict itself.

3.4 Predictable newsworthy events

- The paper uses major US political and sports events as a second source of media distraction.
- These events are known in advance, so strategic actors could forecast that news attention would be diverted.
- The predictable-event test complements the daily news-pressure regressions.

Interpretation: If Israeli attacks increase before predictable events, this supports intentional timing. Random unanticipated news pressure could still crowd out coverage, but it cannot be anticipated in the same way.

3.5 Attack-type measures

- The paper distinguishes attacks likely to generate different levels of international backlash.
- Targeted attacks, non-targeted attacks, fatal attacks, nonfatal attacks, attacks in high- versus low-density areas, and heavy- versus light-weapon attacks are analyzed separately.
- The main prediction is that politically sensitive attacks should be especially likely to shift toward high-news-pressure periods.

Interpretation: Attack-type heterogeneity tests the mechanism. If timing is about hiding reputationally costly actions, the effect should be strongest for attacks that are most visible or morally controversial when noticed.

4 Models and empirical specifications

4.1 Coverage equation

A stylized version of the coverage regression is

$$Coverage_t = \alpha + \beta Attack_{t,t-1} + \gamma NewsPressure_t + X_t' \delta + \varepsilon_t.$$

- $Coverage_t$ is either an indicator that conflict is covered or the length of conflict coverage.
- $Attack_{t,t-1}$ captures whether attacks occurred on the same or previous day and their severity.
- $NewsPressure_t$ is the competing nonconflict news measure.

Interpretation: A negative γ means that competing US news crowds out conflict coverage, even conditional on attack severity.

4.2 Attack timing equation

The main timing regression can be written as

$$Attack_t = \alpha + \sum_{k=-K}^K \beta_k NewsPressure_{t+k} + X_t' \delta + \eta_t.$$

- The key coefficient is typically on $NewsPressure_{t+1}$.
- A positive β_{+1} means attacks at date t are more likely when the next day has high news pressure.
- The regressions include calendar controls and lags of attacks by the opposing side.

Interpretation: Because news about an attack can appear with a delay, high news pressure tomorrow can reduce tomorrow’s coverage of today’s attack. A positive coefficient at $t + 1$ is therefore consistent with strategic timing.

4.3 Severity and victim regressions

For victim counts and severity, the paper estimates variants such as

$$\log(1 + Victims_t) = \alpha + \beta NewsPressure_{t+1} + X_t' \delta + u_t,$$

and negative-binomial count models for the number of victims.

Interpretation: These specifications ask whether news pressure changes only the occurrence of attacks or also the intensity and human cost of attacks.

4.4 Predictable-event test

For predetermined US political and sports events, the design compares attack frequencies on event-related days with other days:

$$Attack_t = \alpha + \beta MajorEvent_{t+1} + X_t' \delta + e_t.$$

Interpretation: Predictable events are important because they are known in advance. A relationship with attacks is harder to explain by reverse causality or purely random news timing.

4.5 Attack-type multinomial models

The paper estimates multinomial-logit and count models for different types of Israeli attacks:

$$Pr(Type_t = j) = f_j(NewsPressure_{t+1}, X_t).$$

Interpretation: These models ask whether news pressure shifts the composition of attacks toward types that are especially likely to trigger criticism if covered by US media.

5 Identification and empirical design

5.1 Core identifying idea

The central identifying idea is that competing US news changes the visibility of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict to US audiences. If the timing of attacks shifts toward high-news-pressure days, and if this shift is stronger for the actor most exposed to US public scrutiny, then the evidence points to strategic media avoidance.

5.2 Main threats and responses

- **Reverse causality from conflict to news pressure.** The corrected news pressure measure is designed to remove the mechanical airtime effect of conflict coverage.
- **General time-series confounding.** The paper includes year, month, day-of-week, and trend controls, and controls for the opposing side's attacks.
- **Conflict intensity episodes.** Major intense episodes are excluded in some specifications to avoid results being driven by extreme periods.
- **Newsworthiness of attack severity.** The paper controls for attack severity and separately analyzes intensity and victim counts.
- **Non-strategic coincidence.** Predictable-event tests are used because strategic actors can forecast those events.

5.3 Why Israeli-Palestinian asymmetry is informative

- The United States is an important diplomatic and reputational audience for Israel.
- Israeli authorities likely have greater capacity to time military operations than decentralized militant groups.
- The absence of a parallel Palestinian timing response makes it less likely that the result is simply a general conflict cycle.

Interpretation: The comparison between Israeli and Palestinian attacks is not a randomized treatment, but it strengthens the mechanism by showing that the effect appears where incentives and capacity are strongest.

5.4 What the design cannot fully prove

- The paper cannot observe internal decision-making calendars or direct orders to time attacks around US news.
- News pressure may still correlate with some unobserved global or local shocks, though the tests and controls reduce this concern.
- The design identifies timing shifts, not the complete welfare effect of media attention on conflict.
- The interpretation depends on US media attention being a meaningful cost to Israeli authorities.

Interpretation: The evidence is strongest as a triangulated empirical case: news pressure reduces coverage, Israeli attacks move around news pressure, predictable-event tests align with strategic timing, and attack-type heterogeneity fits reputational-cost logic.

6 Section-by-section study guide

- **Introduction.** Sets up the puzzle: political actors may hide unpopular actions when media attention is elsewhere.
- **Background and theory.** Explains why media coverage of the Israeli-Palestinian conflict matters for US public opinion and diplomatic costs.
- **Data.** Defines conflict events, US news coverage, news pressure, Google searches, and attack-type classifications.

- **Coverage results.** Shows that competing news reduces conflict coverage.
- **Attack timing results.** Shows that Israeli attacks, but not Palestinian attacks, are more likely before high-news-pressure days.
- **Predictable-event and heterogeneity tests.** Supports the strategic interpretation using major events and attack types.
- **Conclusion.** Emphasizes that media attention affects not only beliefs but also the timing of real political actions.

7 Tables and figures

7.1 Figure 1: Israeli and Palestinian Fatalities by Month + Table 1: News Pressure and the Length of Conflict-Related News

Read:

- Figure 1 shows large spikes in Israeli-caused and Palestinian-caused fatalities during major conflict episodes.
- The vertical line marks the end of the Second Intifada, and shaded bars mark Operation Defensive Shield and the Gaza War.
- Panel B excludes Gaza War and zooms the scale, showing more regular monthly variation that is not dominated by one extreme episode.
- Table 1 shows that conflict-news length is strongly predicted by intense conflict episodes in the first stage.
- In the second stage, conflict-news length has essentially no effect on corrected news pressure, but it reduces uncorrected news pressure mechanically.

Detailed interpretation:

- Figure 1 motivates why the authors sometimes exclude periods of extreme fighting: without doing so, a small number of episodes could dominate the variation.
- Table 1 validates the corrected news-pressure measure. If corrected news pressure were mechanically reduced by conflict coverage, it would not be useful as an independent measure of competing US news.
- The negative coefficient for uncorrected news pressure reflects airtime arithmetic: more conflict news leaves less measured time for other top stories.

Economic message: Figure 1 clarifies the conflict environment; Table 1 clarifies the measurement strategy. Together, they show why the paper needs a careful news-pressure variable and why extreme conflict episodes must be handled cautiously.

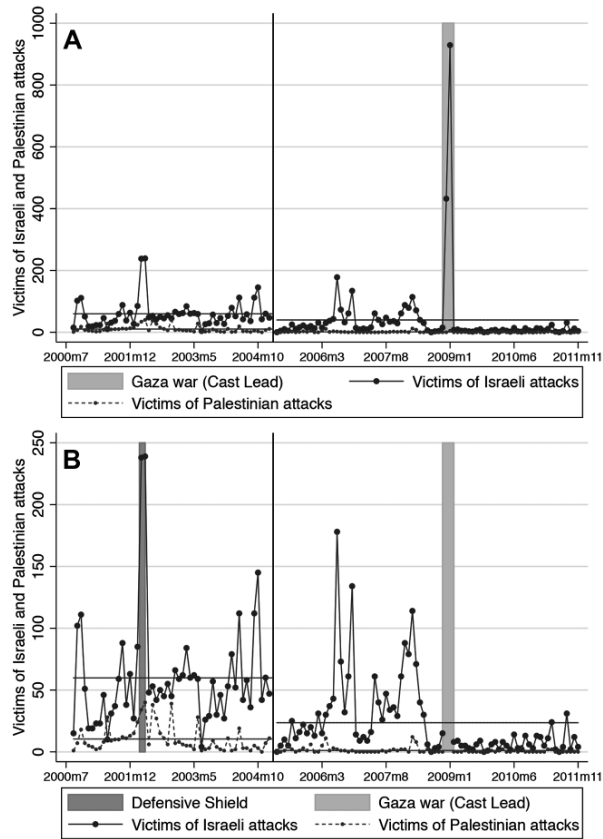


FIG. 1 — Israeli and Palestinian fatalities by month. Panel A: Entire sample period. Panel B:

Figure 1. Israeli and Palestinian fatalities by month.

TABLE 1
NEWS PRESSURE AND THE LENGTH OF CONFLICT-RELATED NEWS

	DEPENDENT VARIABLE		
	Length of Conflict News (1)	Corrected News Pressure (2)	Uncorrected News Pressure (3)
Model	2SLS 1st stage	2SLS 2nd stage	2SLS 2nd stage
A. Full Sample			
Intifada, Defensive Shield, and Cast Lead	5.046*** (1.330)		
Length of conflict news (minutes)		.002 (.006)	-.017*** (.005)
Fixed effects (year, month, day of week)	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	4,003	4,003	4,003
R ²	.288	.096	.144
Fstatistic, excluded instruments	14.40		
B. Sample of Days with an Attack on the Same Day or the Previous Day			
Intifada, Defensive Shield, and Cast Lead	5.291*** (1.235)		
Length of conflict news (minutes)		-.00001 (.006)	-.018*** (.005)
Fixed effects (year, month, day of week)	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	2,331	2,331	2,331
R ²	.295	.133	.200
Fstatistic, excluded instruments	18.35		

NOTE.—The table presents 2SLS regressions with news pressure measures as dependent variables and the length of conflict news as the main endogenous regressor. Column 1 presents the first stage. Columns 2 and 3 present the second stages of the 2SLS regressions with the two measures of news pressure as dependent variables and length of conflict news as the main explanatory variable. Panel A uses the full sample; panel B uses the sample of days with an attack on the same or on the previous day. All regressions include year, calendar-month, and day-of-the-week fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by month $\times$ year are re-

Table 1. News pressure and the length of conflict-related news.

7.2 Table 2: Coverage of Conflict, News Pressure, and Google Searches + Figure 2: Coverage of Conflict in US News

Read:

- Table 2 shows that attacks by either side increase the probability and length of conflict coverage.
- Conditional on attack severity, news pressure reduces conflict coverage: the probability and length of conflict stories fall when competing news is high.
- The Google-search columns show that conflict coverage is associated with public attention: searches rise after conflict news coverage, especially around attacks.
- Figure 2 panel A shows that conflict coverage is highest when attacks occur today or yesterday.
- Figure 2 panel B shows a negative relationship between news pressure and predicted conflict-news length.

Detailed interpretation:

- Table 2 is the key first-step result: news pressure must actually crowd out conflict coverage for the strategic timing mechanism to matter.
- The Google-search evidence helps validate the attention channel. If conflict coverage raises search interest, then avoiding coverage plausibly lowers public attention.
- Figure 2 gives the same result visually: conflict severity matters, but news congestion still reduces coverage conditional on severity.

Economic message: Media attention is scarce. Even violent events receive less attention when other US stories dominate, and this reduction is consequential because it reduces public information demand.

TABLE 2
COVERAGE OF CONFLICT, NEWS PRESSURE, AND GOOGLE SEARCHES

	DEPENDENT VARIABLE					
	Att News on Conflict (1)	Length of Conflict News (2)	Att News on Conflict (3)	Length of Conflict News (4)	Log Daily Volume of Google Searches for Israeli/Palestinian Conflict (5)	(6)
Model	OLS	ML, Neg. Bin.	OLS	ML, Neg. Bin.	OLS	OLS
Sample	All days	All days	All days	All days	All days	All days
Sample period	2004-2011	2005-2011	2004-2011	2005-2011	2004-11	2004-11
Israeli attack (t or $t-1$)	.100***	.580***				
	(.001)	(.185)				
Palestinian attack (t or $t-1$)	.112***	.480***				
	(.002)	(.148)				
News pressure (t)			-.028*	-.592***		
			(.042)	(.267)		
Log(victims Israeli attacks + 1) (t or $t-1$)			.100***	.802***	.130***	.003*
			(.036)	(.080)	(.043)	(.028)
Log(victims Palestinian attacks + 1) (t or $t-1$)			.154***	.572***	.042	.005
			(.034)	(.090)	(.062)	(.027)
Length of conflict news (t or $t-1$)						.112***
						(.016)
Fixed effects (year, month, day of week)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Linear time trend	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Observations	4,005	4,005	2,331	2,331	2,741	2,741
Pseudo R^2	.728	.301	.792	.121	.308	.376

NOTE.—In cols. 1 and 2, we regress measures of news coverage of conflict-related stories on US media on dummies for the occurrence of Israeli and Palestinian attacks on the same or previous day. In cols. 3 and 4, we restrict the sample to days such that an Israeli or a Palestinian attack occurred on the same day or on the previous day, and regress the measures of conflict-related news coverage on the same-day news pressure, controlling for the intensity of the attacks, measured by the log of the number of victims (± 1). In cols. 5 and 6, the log of volume of Google searches for the Israeli-Palestinian conflict is regressed on the severity of attacks and the length of conflict news. All regressions include year, calendar-month, and day-of-the-week fixed effects. Regressions for Google searches also control for the linear trend within each year. The R^2 is reported in cols. 1 and 4 and the pseudo R^2 in all others. Standard errors clustered by month $\times$ year are reported in parentheses.

* $p < .1$,
 ** $p < .05$,
 *** $p < .01$.

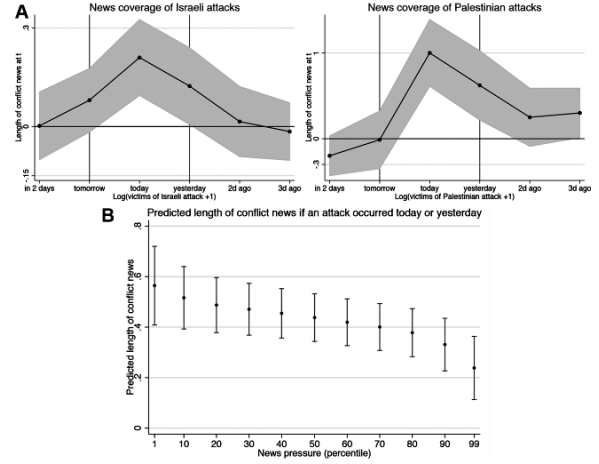


Table 2. Coverage of conflict, news pressure, and Google searches.

Figure 2. Coverage of conflict in US news.

7.3 Figure 3: Israeli and Palestinian Attacks and US News Pressure + Table 3: Israeli Attacks and News Pressure, Part 1

Read:

- Figure 3 plots event-time coefficients around news pressure for Israeli and Palestinian attacks.
- The positive coefficient for Israeli attacks at $t+1$ indicates that Israeli attacks are more likely immediately before high-news-pressure days.
- The corresponding Palestinian coefficients are close to zero and statistically weak.
- Table 3 formalizes this pattern for Israeli attacks, showing positive coefficients on news pressure at $t+1$ for occurrence and victim outcomes.

Detailed interpretation:

- The key timing is not contemporaneous news pressure; it is the next day's pressure. This is consistent with attacks being timed before the day on which media coverage would otherwise occur.
- The Israeli results appear for both the probability of an attack and intensity measures such as log victims and victim counts.
- The lag/lead structure helps rule out a generic association between conflict intensity and news pressure. The sharpness around $t+1$ is the timing pattern the mechanism predicts.

Economic message: The main behavioral result is that the actor most exposed to US media scrutiny appears to shift violence toward moments when US attention will be crowded out.

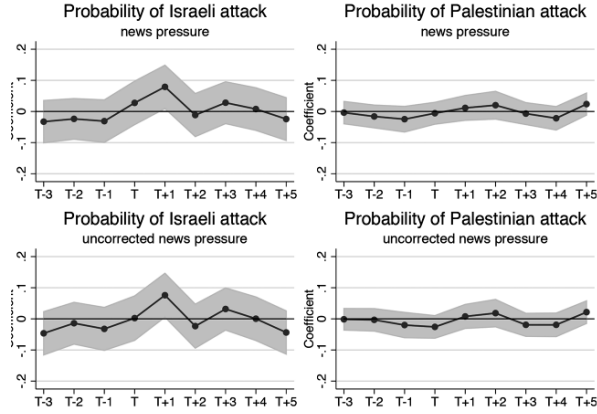


FIG. 3.—Israeli and Palestinian attacks and US news pressure. The figure reports the estimated coefficients (and respective 95 percent confidence intervals for Newey-West standard errors) from the regressions of occurrence of Israeli and Palestinian attacks on news pressure between 3 days before and 5 days after the event from the estimation of equation (1)

Figure 3. Israeli and Palestinian attacks and US news pressure.

TABLE 3
ISRAELI ATTACKS AND NEWS PRESSURE

	DEPENDENT VARIABLE						
	Occurrence (1)	Occurrence (2)	Occurrence (3)	Ln(1 + Victims) (4)	Ln(1 + Victims) (5)	Ln(1 + Victims) (6)	Number of Victims (7)
	OLS	OLS	OLS	OLS	OLS	OLS	ML Neg. Bin.
A. News Pressure							
$re\ t$	.074** (.052)	.030 (.054)	.026 (.035)	.130** (.052)	.058 (.050)	.028 (.047)	.034 (.142)
$re\ t + 1$		.084** (.034)	.078** (.035)		.138*** (.047)	.121** (.049)	.481*** (.159)
$re\ t - 1$			-.026 (.035)			-.035 (.046)	-.209 (.156)
attacks (previous day)			.104*** (.030)			.220*** (.057)	.434*** (.101)
attacks (previous week)			.086*** (.021)			.168*** (.036)	.403*** (.089)
attacks (week before previous)			.068*** (.022)			.141*** (.036)	.301*** (.086)
t (year, month, day of week)	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes	Yes
s	4.048	4.045	4.024	4.048	4.045	4.024	4.024
r^2	.181	.183	.196	.175	.177	.195	.069

Table 3. Israeli attacks and news pressure, part 1.

7.4 Table 3: Israeli Attacks and News Pressure, Part 2 + Table 4: Palestinian Attacks and News Pressure

Read:

- Table 3 part 2 continues the Israeli results using uncorrected news pressure and additional robustness columns.
- The positive timing pattern for Israeli attacks is present under both news-pressure definitions.
- Table 4 applies the same structure to Palestinian attacks.
- Palestinian attacks do not show the same positive response to future news pressure.

Detailed interpretation:

- The contrast between Tables 3 and 4 is central. If high news pressure simply reflected regional tensions or measurement artifacts, both sides would be expected to respond similarly.
- The Israeli response is consistent with a strategic actor timing operations around media attention, while the Palestinian non-response suggests either weaker incentives, weaker capacity, or different objectives.
- The two-table comparison is the paper's cleanest actor-level falsification test.

Economic message: Strategic media avoidance is not a universal property of conflict; it depends on who bears the media cost and who can shift the timing of actions.

	B. Uncorrected News Pressure					
1 news pressure t	.027 (.034)	-.007 (.034)	-.003 (.036)	.021 (.065)	-.023 (.054)	-.037 (.049)
1 news pressure $t + 1$			.063* (.033)		.080* (.048)	.341** (.164)
1 news pressure $t - 1$			-.030 (.035)		-.031 (.046)	-.145 (.155)
attacks (previous day)			.105*** (.030)		.221*** (.057)	.435*** (.100)
attacks (previous week)			.086*** (.022)		.168*** (.036)	.408*** (.091)
attacks (week before previous)			.099*** (.022)		.144*** (.036)	.308*** (.087)
corrected P	No	No	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
x (year, month, day of week)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
s	4.048 .180	4.045 .181	4.024 .194	4.048 .175	4.045 .174	4.024 .192

he dependent variables are the occurrence of Israeli attacks (cols. 1-3), the log of the number of fatalities of Israeli attacks + 1 (cols. 4-6), and the number of fatalities of Israeli attacks (col. 7). OLS regressions are presented in cols. 1-6 and an ML negative binomial regression in col. 7. All include year, calendar-month, and day-of-the-week fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by month $\times$ year are reported in parentheses in i; Newey-West standard errors are reported in parentheses in all other columns. Panel A uses the baseline news pressure measure and panel B uses news pressure.

i.

ii.

TABLE 4 PALESTINIAN ATTACKS AND NEWS PRESSURE						
	DEPENDENT VARIABLE					
	Occurrence (1)	Occurrence (2)	Occurrence (3)	Ln(1 + Victims) (4)	Ln(1 + Victims) (5)	Ln(1 + Victims) (6)
t	OLS -.008 (.013)	OLS -.015 (.013)	OLS -.004 (.018)	OLS -.014 (.016)	OLS -.023 (.018)	OLS -.016 (.022)
$t + 1$			.013 (.018)	.021 (.018)	.017 (.019)	.023 (.019)
$t - 1$			-.023 (.021)	-.023 (.021)	-.027 (.024)	-.027 (.024)
previous day			.015 (.009)	.015 (.009)	.021** (.010)	.281* (.185)
previous week			.013** (.006)	.013** (.006)	.012** (.006)	.707* (.301)
week before previous			.006 (.006)	.006 (.006)	.003 (.006)	.310 (.465)
x (year, month, day of week)	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
s	4.048 .088	4.045 .088	4.024 .089	4.048 .085	4.045 .085	4.024 .088
p^0	.007 .048**	.007 .048**	.007 .048**	.014** .029**	.014** .029**	.014** .029**

he dependent variables are the occurrence of Palestinian attacks (col. 1-3), the log of the number of fatalities of Palestinian attacks + 1 and the number of fatalities of Palestinian attacks (col. 7). OLS regressions are presented in cols. 1-6 and an ML negative binomial regression in col. 7. All include year, calendar-month, and day-of-the-week fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by month $\times$ year are reported in panels 1 and 6. Newey-West standard errors are reported in parentheses in all other columns. The last row presents the p -values of the test for zero effects of news pressure for Israeli and Palestinian attacks (presented in panel A of table 3) calculated using seemingly unrelated

i.

ii.

Table 3. Israeli attacks and news pressure, part 2.

Table 4. Palestinian attacks and news pressure.

7.5 Figure 4: Israeli and Palestinian Attacks and Other Predictable Newsworthy Events + Table 5: Israeli Attacks and News Pressure under Different Conditions, Part 1

Read:

- Figure 4 compares attack probabilities before major US political or sports events versus other days.
- Israeli attacks are much more likely around major events: 53.16 percent versus 38.67 percent in the figure.
- Palestinian attack probabilities are essentially the same across event and non-event days: 6.96 percent versus 6.79 percent.
- Table 5 starts the heterogeneity analysis for Israeli attacks, asking whether the news-pressure effect is stronger under different political and media conditions.

Detailed interpretation:

- Major political and sports events are useful because they are anticipated. This moves the evidence closer to intentional timing than purely unexpected news shocks.
- The Israeli-Palestinian contrast reappears in the predictable-event design, strengthening the interpretation that Israeli timing responds to expected US attention.
- Table 5 extends the question from average effects to mechanisms: when should the timing incentives be strongest?

Economic message: The evidence from predictable events suggests strategic anticipation: attacks move not only when news pressure is high, but when high news pressure can plausibly be forecast.

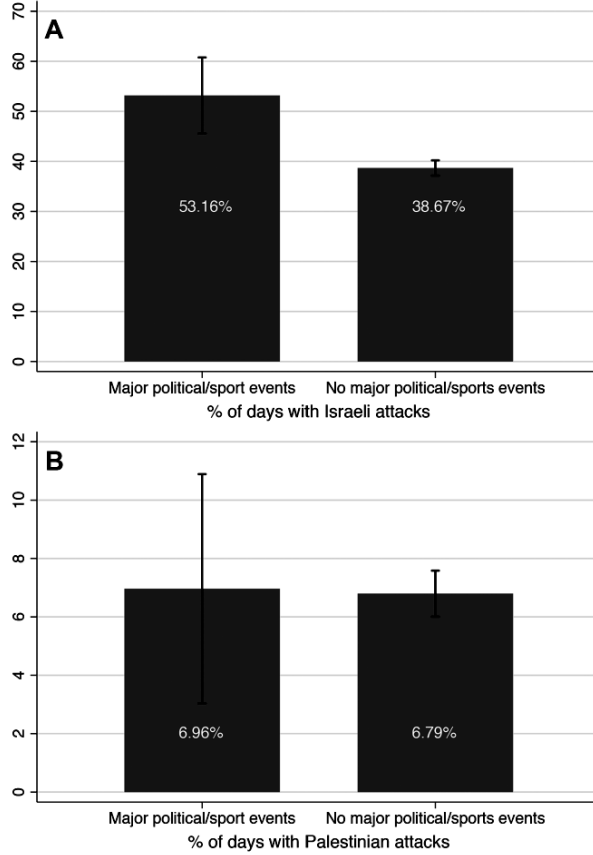


FIG. 4. Israeli and Palestinian attacks and other predictable and unpredictable events.

Figure 4. Israeli and Palestinian attacks and predictable US newsworthy events.

TABLE 5
ATTACKS AND NEXT-DAY NEWS PRESSURE DRIVEN BY PREDICTABLE POLITICAL AND SPORTS EVENTS

	DEPENDENT VARIABLE						
	P_{t-1} (1)	Uncorrected P_{t-1} (2)	Occurrence (3)	Occurrence (4)	Occurrence (5)	Number of Victims (6)	Number of Victims (7)
	2SLS 1st stage	2SLS 1st stage	2SLS 2nd stage	2SLS 2nd stage	OLS Reduced form	ML neg. bin. IV 2nd stage	ML neg. bin. IV 2nd stage
A. Israeli Attacks and Predictable Newsworthy Events							
orts events $t + 1$	.177*** (.035)	.190*** (.034)			.190*** (.041)		.413** (.171)
re $t + 1$			.615** (.246)			2.493*** (.877)	
l news pressure $t + 1$				.574*** (.220)			2.325*** (.792)
s (year, month, ck)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
nian attacks	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
s	4,046	4,046	4,046	4,046	4,049	4,046	4,049
i	.117	.133	.128	.126	.195	.	.068
cluded instruments	25.04	31.68	25.04	31.68	...	25.04	31.68
B. Palestinian Attacks and Predictable Newsworthy Events							
orts events $t + 1$	.130*** (.040)	.152*** (.040)			-.018 (.014)		-.017 (.331)
re $t + 1$			-.132 (.102)			.798 (2.222)	
l news pressure $t + 1$				-.121 (.089)			.732 (2.031)

Table 5. Israeli attacks and news pressure under different conditions, part 1.

7.6 Table 5: Israeli Attacks and News Pressure under Different Conditions, Part 2 + Table 6: The Urgency of Attacks and the Likelihood of Civilian Casualties, Part 1

Read:

- Table 5 part 2 continues the analysis of conditions under which Israeli attacks respond to news pressure.
- The heterogeneity results ask whether the effect is tied to political pressure, likely news coverage, and observability.
- Table 6 part 1 separates targeted and nontargeted attacks and fatal versus nonfatal attacks.
- The news-pressure effect is stronger for non-targeted attacks and fatal attacks, categories more likely to generate criticism when covered.

Detailed interpretation:

- Table 6 moves beyond timing to the type of violence. A pure operational-capacity story would not necessarily predict stronger timing effects for politically sensitive attack types.
- The non-targeted and fatal categories are more likely to impose civilian casualties or create reputational costs.
- This supports the idea that the objective is to avoid bad publicity rather than simply to exploit military convenience.

Economic message: If news pressure matters most for morally or diplomatically costly attacks, then media coverage is functioning as a reputational constraint on military action.

t (year, day of week)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
attacks	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
s	4.046	4.046	4.046	4.046	4.049	4.046	4.046	4.049
cluded instruments	.096	.108	.064	.070	.085	. . .	. . .	.097
$= \beta_{\text{news}}^{\text{IV}}$	11.90	14.73	11.90	14.73	. . .	11.90	14.73	. . .
	.003***	.003***	.003***	.002***	.019**	.017**	.002***	

C. Placebo: Israeli Attacks and Unpredictable Newsworthy Events

$et\ t + 1$	.082*** (.025)	.078*** (.026)		-.023 (.045)				-.131 (.162)
$re\ t + 1$			-.278 (.571)		-1.081 (2.047)			
news pressure $t + 1$				-.291 (.593)		-1.132 (2.149)		

t (year, month, sk)	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
ian attacks	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
s	4.046	4.046	4.046	4.046	4.049	4.046	4.046	4.049
cluded instruments	.104	.119	.161	.163	.193	. . .	. . .	.068
$_{\text{news}} = \beta_{\text{news}}^{\text{IV}}$	10.710	9.112	10.710	9.112	. . .	10.710	9.112	. . .
	.119	.140	.054**	.191	.227	. . .	.095*	

The table presents IV regressions with the dummy for major sports and political events used as an instrument for news pressure in panels A and B. For onset of a US-based disaster in panel C. Robust standard errors adjusted for clusters by month $\times$ year are in parentheses. All tests for of β^{IV} coefficients for the occurrence of attacks come from the estimation of the system of the corresponding equations with GMM. All tests for of β^{IV} coefficients for the severity of attacks come from the GMM estimation of the system of log-linear equations with log (number of as a dependent variable rather than the ML negative binomial). To compare the reduced-form estimates for Israeli and Palestinian attacks, we estimate seemingly unrelated regressions. To compare the estimates for the reduced-form estimates for the Israeli attacks between the baseline eqs, we estimate a single equation, in which the Israeli attacks (or the log of their victims) are regressed simultaneously on the dummies for onset and for the important predictable events.

Table 5. Israeli attacks and news pressure under different conditions, part 2.

TABLE 6
THE URGENCY OF ATTACKS AND THE LIKELIHOOD OF CIVILIAN CASUALTIES

MULTINOMIAL LOGIT MODEL: DAILY OUTCOME RELATIVE TO DAYS WITH NO ATTACK			
(1a)	(1b)	ML NEG. BIN. MODEL (2)	ML NEG. BIN. MODEL (3)
A. Targeted vs. Nontargeted Attacks, Sample: 2001–11			
Days with Targeted Attacks	Days with Nontargeted Attacks	Victims of Targeted Killings	Victims of Nontargeted Attacks
$re\ t + 1$	.006 (.010)	.007** (.042)	.193 (.408)
s	3.6	35.3	.158
s	4.025	4.025	4.025
a = 1b	.056**		
B. Fatal vs. Nonfatal Attacks, Sample: 2005–11			
Days with Nonfatal Attacks	Days with Fatal Attacks	Injuries	Fatalities
$re\ t + 1$	-.047 (.052)	.083* (.047)	-.047 (.177)
s	48.6	27.0	711*** (.242)
s	2.485	2.485	2.485
a = 1b	.147		

Table 6. Urgency of attacks and likelihood of civilian casualties, part 1.

7.7 Table 6: The Urgency of Attacks and the Likelihood of Civilian Casualties, Part 2 + Figure 5: Types of Attacks and News Pressure

Read:

- Table 6 part 2 separates attacks by location density and weapon type.
- The news-pressure effect is stronger for attacks in high-density areas and attacks with heavy weapons.
- Figure 5 visualizes the same heterogeneity through lag/lead plots and multinomial-logit marginal effects.
- The figure shows that high-news-pressure timing is most visible for attack types that are more likely to cause public criticism.

Detailed interpretation:

- High-density-area and heavy-weapon attacks are especially likely to cause civilian casualties or images that travel through the media.
- The visual evidence in Figure 5 complements Table 6 by showing timing around $t + 1$ rather than only average coefficients.
- The consistency across attack-type definitions reduces concern that the main result reflects a single arbitrary classification.

Economic message: The more damaging or publicly costly the attack type, the stronger the incentive to undertake it when the world is least likely to watch.

C. Attacks in Less vs. More Densely Populated Areas (LDP vs. MDP), Sample: 2005–11				
	Days with Attacks, LDP Areas	Days with Attacks, MDP Areas	Victims, LDP Areas	Victims, MDP Areas
re $t + 1$	-.054	.087*	-.004	.606**
s	(.052)	(.048)	(.133)	(.243)
a = 1b	30.3	2,483	2,483	2,483
		.123		
D. Attacks with Light Weapons (LW) vs. Heavy Weapons (HW), Sample: 2005–11				
	Days with Attacks Using LW Only	Days with Attacks Using HW	Victims with LWs	Victims with HWs
re $t + 1$	-.038	.080**	-.137	.789**
s	(.046)	(.036)	(.108)	(.356)
a = 1b	55.2	2,449	1,962	2,449
re (lags)		20.1		
nian attacks	Yes	.092*	Yes	Yes
i (year, month, day of week)	Yes		Yes	Yes

column 1 reports results of multinomial logit regressions with three outcomes, with days without attacks the baseline (comparison) outcome. Effects on the probability are reported in col. 1. Columns 2 and 3 report results of ML negative binomial regressions. Robust standard errors clusters by month $\times$ year are in parentheses in col. 1, and Newey-West standard errors are reported in parentheses in cols. 2 and 3.

† .1.

Table 6. Urgency of attacks and likelihood of civilian casualties, part 2.

7.8 Table 7: Google Search Volume, Conflict-Related News, and Timing of Attacks

Read:

- Table 7 studies whether conflict coverage changes Google search volume about the Israeli-Palestinian conflict.
- Conflict news on the day after an Israeli attack is positively associated with search volume.
- The strongest positive coefficients appear when conflict news follows an Israeli attack on the previous day.
- These results validate the idea that US news coverage affects public attention.

Detailed interpretation:

- The Google-search evidence matters because coverage could otherwise be treated as a journalistic outcome with unclear audience consequences.
- If conflict coverage increases searches, then avoiding coverage plausibly reduces public scrutiny and political pressure.
- Table 7 therefore supports the mechanism connecting media crowd-out to strategic timing of attacks.

Economic message: Media coverage matters because audiences respond. The strategic value of high news pressure comes from reducing not only airtime, but also public attention.

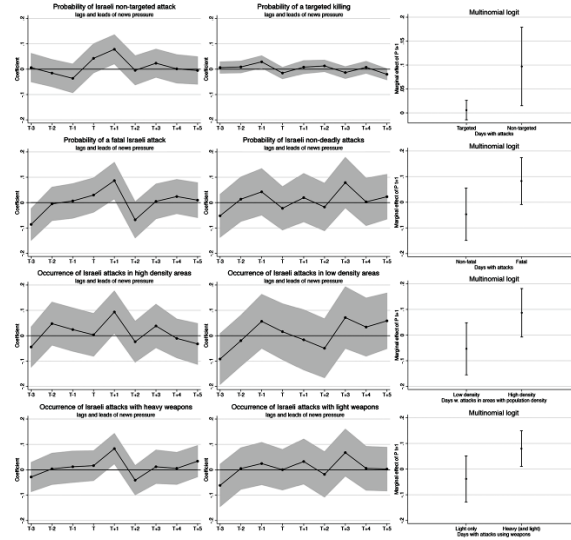


FIG. 5.—Types of attacks and news pressure. The plots in the first two columns report the relationship between Israeli attacks of different types and the lags and leads of news pressure (along with respective 90 percent confidence intervals). Column 3 presents the estimated marginal effects (along with their 95 percent confidence intervals) of a change in news pressure on the probability of an Israeli attack of a certain type from the multinomial logit specification presented in column 1 of table 6. Color version available as an online supplement.

Figure 5. Types of attacks and news pressure.

TABLE 7
GOOGLE SEARCH VOLUME, CONFLICT-RELATED NEWS, AND TIMING OF ATTACKS

	DEPENDENT VARIABLE: LOG DAILY VOLUME OF GOOGLE SEARCHES FOR ISRAELI- PALESTINIAN CONFLICT			
	OLS (1)	OLS (2)	OLS (3)	OLS (4)
Any conflict news, $t \times$ Israeli attack, same day	.014 (.114)	-.058 (.127)		
Any conflict news, $t \times$ Israeli attack, previous day	.368*** (.101)	.295** (.127)		
Any conflict news, $t - 1 \times$ Israeli attack, same day		.047 (.143)		
Any conflict news, $t - 1 \times$ Israeli attack, previous day		.329*** (.119)		
Length of conflict news, $t \times$ Israeli attack, same day			-.003 (.034)	-.044 (.040)
Length of conflict news, $t \times$ Israeli attack, previous day			.109*** (.030)	.108*** (.039)
Length of conflict news, $t - 1 \times$ Israeli attack, same day				-.034 (.044)
Length of conflict news, $t - 1 \times$ Israeli attack, previous day				.114*** (.039)
Occurrence dummies and log victims of attacks on both sides, t and $t - 1$	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Occurrence dummies and log victims of attacks on both sides, $t - 2$	No	Yes	No	Yes
Fixed effects (day of week and month); linear time trend	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Respective conflict news measure, $t \times$ no Israeli attack, t or $t - 1$	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Respective conflict news measure, $t - 1 \times$ no Israeli attack, $t - 1$ or $t - 2$	No	Yes	No	Yes
Observations	2,773	2,741	2,773	2,741
R^2	.307	.326	.323	.345
p -value: same-day coverage vs. previous-day coverage, t	.053*	.133	.073*	.052*
p -value: same-day coverage vs. previous-day				

Table 7. Google search volume, conflict-related news, and timing of attacks.

8 Detailed result map

- **Measurement result.** Corrected news pressure is not mechanically driven by conflict-news length, unlike uncorrected news pressure.
- **Coverage result.** Conditional on attack severity, higher news pressure reduces conflict coverage in US news.
- **Attention result.** Conflict coverage is associated with higher Google search volume for the Israeli-Palestinian conflict.
- **Main timing result.** Israeli attacks are more likely before high-news-pressure days; Palestinian attacks are not.
- **Predictable-event result.** Israeli attacks are more likely around major US political and sports events, while Palestinian attacks are not.
- **Attack-type result.** The timing effect is strongest for non-targeted, fatal, high-density-area, and heavy-weapon Israeli attacks.
- **Mechanism.** The results are consistent with a reputational-cost channel: actors time costly actions for periods when international attention is diverted.

9 Short summary

- The paper studies whether violent political actions are timed to avoid media scrutiny.
- It uses daily data from the Israeli-Palestinian conflict and US television news coverage from 2000 to 2011.
- The key explanatory variable is US news pressure: the amount of nonconflict news competing for airtime.
- News pressure reduces conflict coverage, conditional on the occurrence and severity of attacks.
- Conflict coverage is linked to public attention as measured by Google searches.
- Israeli attacks are more likely immediately before high-news-pressure days.
- Palestinian attacks do not show the same pattern.
- Israeli attacks are also more likely before predictable US political and sports events.
- The response is stronger for attack types that are especially likely to trigger international criticism.
- The paper concludes that media attention is an important constraint on state action and that actors can strategically exploit audience distraction.

10 Conclusion

10.1 Core conclusion

Durante and Zhuravskaya show that the timing of violent actions can be shaped by the media agenda. Israeli attacks against Palestinians are more likely when US news pressure is expected to be high, meaning the attack is less likely to receive substantial US coverage. Palestinian attacks do not display the same timing pattern.

10.2 Economic intuition

The core intuition is a scarce-attention model. News programs have limited airtime, and audiences have limited attention. When unrelated major stories dominate US news, the same conflict event receives less

coverage. If media coverage generates reputational, diplomatic, or political costs, then actors who can time their actions have an incentive to act when the audience is distracted.

10.3 Why the evidence is persuasive

The paper does not rely on a single correlation. It first shows that news pressure crowds out conflict coverage. It then shows that Israeli attacks shift toward high-news-pressure periods. It validates the attention channel with Google searches. It uses predictable US political and sports events to support the strategic-timing interpretation. Finally, it shows that politically costly attack types respond more strongly.

10.4 Incremental lesson for political economy

The paper broadens the study of media effects. Media does not simply inform citizens after events occur; the expected media environment can shape what political actors do and when they do it. This means transparency is endogenous: actors can strategically choose moments when scrutiny is temporarily weak.

10.5 Policy implications

The results imply that constant monitoring may matter as much as average media freedom. If media attention is concentrated on a small set of topics, other actions may occur in the shadows. International organizations, watchdogs, and journalists may need systems that maintain attention during crowded news cycles.

10.6 Limitations

The paper cannot directly observe decision makers choosing dates because of US news. It also cannot fully measure all sources of international scrutiny, including European media, local media, or diplomatic private information. The results are therefore best read as strong indirect evidence of strategic timing rather than direct proof of internal motives.

10.7 Final takeaway

The paper's central message is that public attention is a strategic constraint. When the world is not watching, political actors may change the timing and composition of their actions. In this setting, the media agenda becomes part of the technology of conflict.